August 31 1944
Reveille 5.40, 'Prepare to move by 6', but of course we didn't. Spent the morning reading. Two parties of German prisoners passed, looking dishevelled but not unhappy. Tanks still moving up – hundreds must have passed since we came here, Shermans and Churchills. Shelling almost stopped. Insects a terrific nuisance. Eventually left just before dusk, halted about half an hour by two dead bullocks, which stank abominably. Crossed the river and harboured near it. Only 50 min stag [guard duty] each. Shelling of area during night, Dick and Helme saw white hot shrapnel whizzing past. Fortunately I felt very sleepy, so didn't bother much.



A Sherman tank passes a Churchill carrying infantry during the 46th Division's assault on the Gothic Line, September 2 1944. (Imperial War Museum)

"Suddenly Jerry let loose, guns or mortars"

Sept 1 1944
Five years since Germany invaded Poland. We stayed in the harbour area all day, and I got some clothes washed. As usual, difficulty in getting water. More prisoners passed. As usual, twice today we have been told to be ready to move by a certain time. I think Rowberry must give these orders just to keep us on the hop.

About dusk we mounted the mortars just below the trucks. Suddenly Jerry let loose, guns or mortars, and dropped several rounds in the area. We threw ourselves flat during the first burst then dashed down into some German dug-outs. We hadn't dared enter them in daylight, for fear of mines, but no one hesitated when the bombardment started. We slept there all night too. Indigestion again.

Sept 2 1944
Stayed in the area most of the morning – reading German newspapers. Moved off again, put the mortars in position about mid-day. Slit-trenches already dug. We improved them a bit. Just after I had got my tiffin [lunch] we began firing heavily – fired about 30-40 rounds. No trouble, and I got my meal in bits between firing. Shortly after dusk, as we were standing near our trenches, an enemy mortar bomb landed about 15 yds away. We didn't have time to duck – I was upright when I saw the flash, but I dived on top of Dick right after it. He got a bit of shrapnel in his wrist – apparently not serious. I put my field dressing on it, and stuck in that slit trench for an hour, bomb-happy.

This bomb, and others, sent shrapnel through the sides of our trailer and Cpl Hartley's truck. A big hole it made in the ground, too. Then the towing party arrived, about 2AM. (Tat's truck wouldn't start, and was left at the last place). Joe Dunkerley broke his towing bar pulling it, then it conked on the road, and a bulldozer shoved it off the track, wheels and axles smashed.

(During the morning we saw one of our bombers come down, and the crew bale out.)



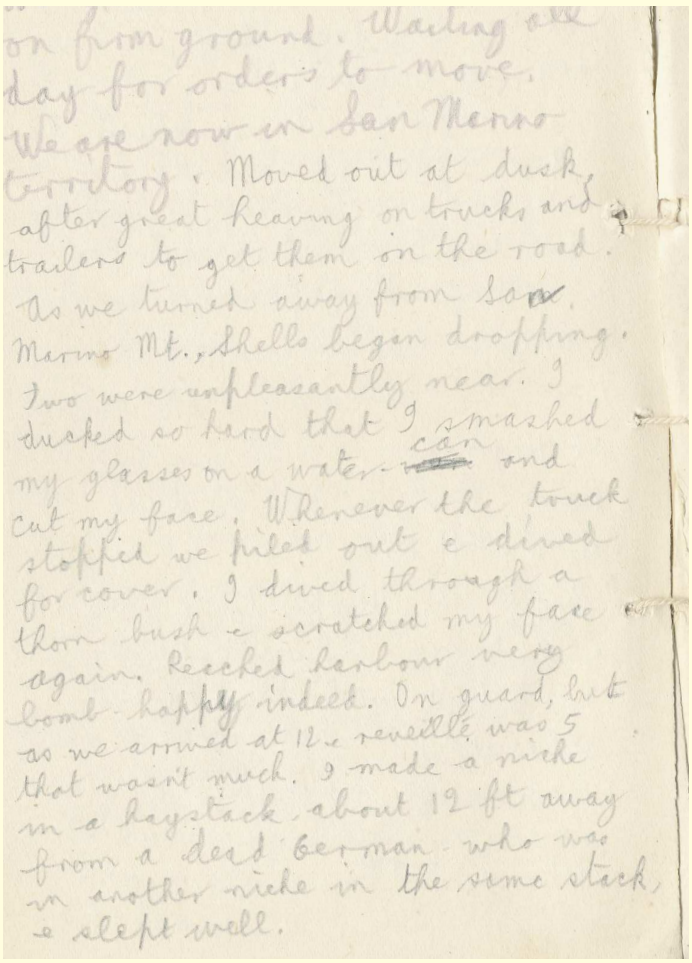
B-24L 'Stevanovitch II' of the 464th Bomber Group hit by German anti-aircraft fire over Luggo, Italy, 10 April 1945. (Only one of the crew of ten survived.)

(Photo from US Air Force)

Sept 3 1944
Spent the morning spreading 4 mortars and kits between 3 trucks, also getting water. Moved off after tiffin. Halted on the road outside a town – which Jerry was bombarding. Shrapnel came flying round, so we dived into the hedge. We went into position again, and had several tries at bedding in. Two detachments did a shoot. Douglas doesn't seem inclined to stand any hanky-panky from Rowberry and co.



The rectangle at the top left of the above map gives some indication of the area where Jim was fighting in autumn 1944. The Gothic Line map below shows a small area just south of Rimini and east of San Marino.

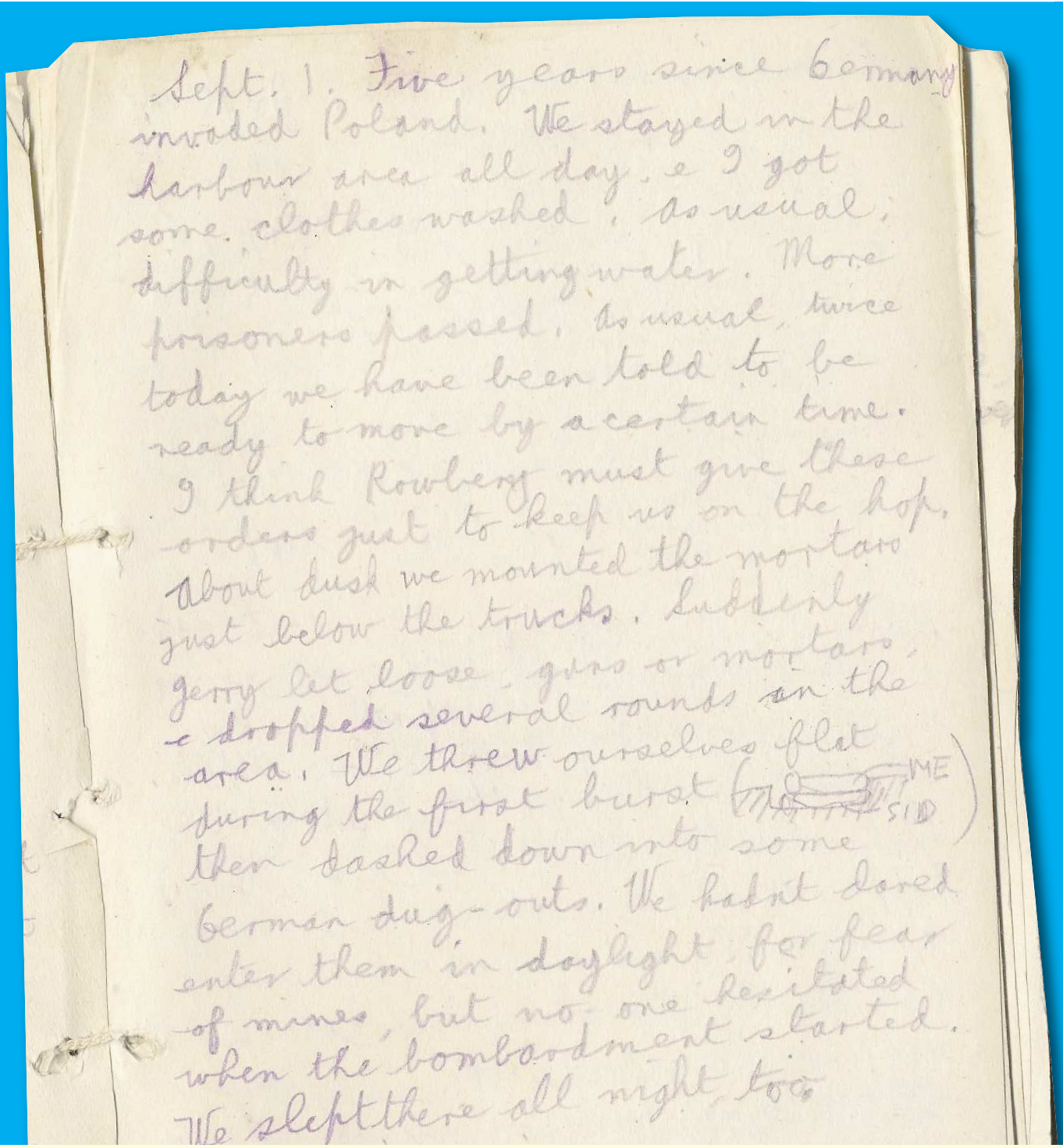


Jim's diaries take the form of an outer cover into which variously coloured pieces of paper, hacked to size, are tied. The ones written abroad are largely in pencil - presumably because of ink unavailability.





Above: three scruffy musketeers in an off-duty moment: Jim Dixon in work overalls; Nobby Clarke; Dick Gill (presumably the young man referred to in the Sept 2 story).The picture was taken in 1945 in Athens. Jim and the others were briefly posted from Italy to Greece in February of that year, returning to Italy in April.


Sept. 1. Five years since Germany invaded Poland. We stayed in the harbour area all day. & I got some clothes washed, as usual, difficulty in getting water. More prisoners passed. As usual, twice today we have been told to be ready to move by a certain time. I think Rowbery must give these orders just to keep us on the hop. About dusk we mounted the mortars just below the trucks. Suddenly Jerry let loose guns or mortars, dropped several rounds in the area. We threw ourselves flat during the first burst (SOMME SID) then dashed down into some German dug-outs. We hadn't dared enter them in daylight, for fear of mines, but no one hesitated when the bombardment started. We slept there all night, too.

Fighting on the Gothic Line

After the fall of Rome in June, the Germans retired to their heavily defended last major defensive line along the jagged Apennine Mountains chain ending at the Adriatic coast just south of Rimini.

Operation Olive, the major allied offensive in the autumn of 1944, (sometimes known as the Battle of Rimini) was launched on 23 August. Over 1,200,000 men participated in this battle, which took the form of a pincer manoeuvre carried out by the British Eighth and the US Fifth Army.

To quote from **'Eighth Army News'** from July 1945:

> *...on **August 25** the attack was opened on the Gothic Line, which was breached west of Pesaro on **August 31**. Between **September 5 and 12** bitter battles took place for the Coriano-Gemmano Ridge, and there were heavy casualties on both sides. The ensuing advance was marked by heavy fighting south of the River Marecchia, which ended with the capture of Rimini on **September 21**. ...*
>
> *Cesena fell on **October 21**, Forli **November 9**, Ravenna **Dec. 4,** and Faenza **December 16**. Thirteenth Corps on the left had advanced with the American Fifth Army through mountainous terrain to within 12 miles south east of Bologna.*

According to Lieutenant-General Oliver Leese, Commander of the Eighth army: 'The battle of Rimini was one of the hardest battles of the Eighth Army. The fighting was comparable to El Alamein, Mareth and the Gustav Line (Monte-Cassino).'

The Battle of Gemmano, particularly bitter, has been nicknamed by some historians the 'Cassino of the Adriatic'. Assaults - including those by the British 56th Division and the British 46th Division - were eventually successful. At the same time, a similar battle was taking place at Croce. It took five days of constant fighting before the 56th Division captured it.

However, progress became held up because of the onset of the autumn rains, which caused mud slides and swollen rivers. Another factor was the need to withdraw troops to other areas of the war.

"Major Bob wounded, 1 man killed …. The Gothic Line is broken, though"

Sept 4 1944
We stayed in the area all day, doing maintenance on the mortars and reloading the trucks. Lydon nearly ditched a carrier, but we saved it. Jerry seems out of range now, so we weren't bothered. The Canadians are in Rimini. From a ridge we can see the town. The OP was hit yesterday, Major Bob wounded, 1 man killed, several wounded. All ours had remarkable escapes, shrapnel dents in the carrier. The Gothic Line is broken, though.

Sept 5 1944
We stayed put, while the battle rolled forward. … I wrote home, fetched water and got my hair cut. It is said that we shall rest for a few days. I spent a lot of my time filling in our advances on my map, Brussels, Antwerp, Breda, Namur etc. I was on guard again tonight - the old style - 6 men and 2 NCOs. I was on first stag. Of course, all were sleeping in the open, feeling perfectly secure, when:- boom, whee-ee! Jerry opened up, not so far away either. He kept it up occasionally for an hour, not near but shrapnel was around. I kept down, and most of them got up and took cover.



A 25-pdr of 11th Field Regiment in a waterlogged position near Scorticate, Italy, 3- 8 October 1944. (Picture from Imperial War Museum)

Sept 6 1944
…. We went back about 2 miles, and joined C Coy for 5 days refitting. Cpt. Barrett made it painfully clear that it will not be a rest period. I spent the aft washing all my clothes. Chilly again, and a slight shower – end of summer. We got our oak tree flashes. A bit of duck for supper.

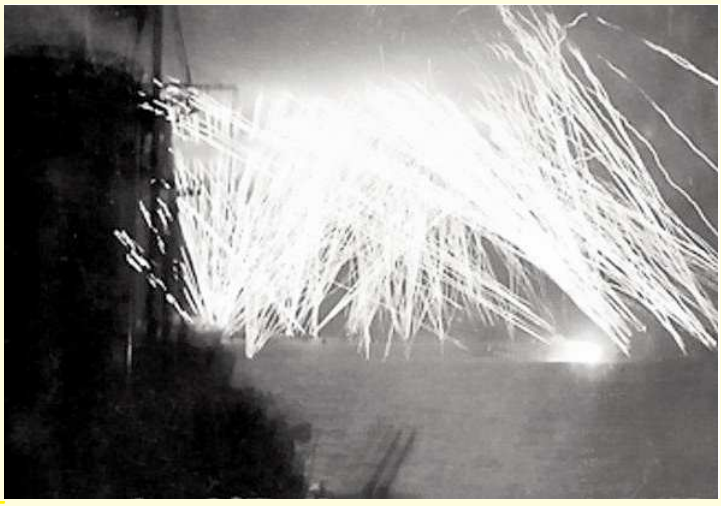
Sept 7 1944
Rain all last night, cleared up just in time for me to get up for breakfast. Back to parades etc., though not terrific bull-shit. Fine all morning, so we cleaned the mortar. Rain almost all aft. and evening, we just had to lie in the bivvy. Several were rained out, Cpl Etches and Sid went in the truck.

Sept 8 1944
Rowberry took me up to the village as interpreter, to try and find a barber, but there wasn't one. We kept on with maintenance. … I spent the aft digging a pit in my half of the bivvy, while Dick (who dislikes being flooded out) dug a slit trench. Much more comfortable now. It didn't rain all day, though the sky remained cloudy and the ground muddy.

Let's hope it will enable the 56th Div to push on. [Battle of Gemmano?] I sewed my oak flashes on. Liege and Ostend taken.

Sept 9 1944
Fine all day, the ground improved. ... Warned after tiffin to be prepared to move tonight. Packed up. Got pay, the first for 3 weeks. Moved about 8, halted in a village for about 3 hrs. Jerry opened up with 88 mms just beyond and below us, so we dived into a house till it was time to move. Went then to a farm to harbour.

Just getting down when a Jerry plane came over and dropped bombs some way away. The A.A. put up a real Brock's benefit [free display by Brock's fireworks], thousands of red tracer shells, a marvellous sight. I got my bed under the truck and slept. One trailer ditched with a puncture, and Rowberry ran a bike into a carrier and bashed it up.



Tracer fire from anti-aircraft guns of British warship, Normandy, June 44 (Imperial War Museum)

Sept 10 (Sun) 1944
The ration truck went out to fetch a wireless set last night, got held up and couldn't get back till 10 this morning. Breakfast about 10.30! … About dusk we had orders to dig in. I managed to scrape a hole before complete darkness.

Sept 11 1944
Had a first parade and then were supposed to do maintenance, but did almost nothing. I deepened my sleeping pit, though, and got on well with some Eytie kids. Our lads held up at Gemmaino. [Presumably misspelling of Gemmano.]

Sept 12 1944
Moved off about 10, in relays. The first relay appeared to us to be rather narrowly missed by a shell. I got talking quite a lot with the kids again. After one wrong turning we crossed the river to Shell-happy Valley. There were whizzes and bangs all day, and we dived in and out of trenches like rabbits. No really near ones, though. Slit trenches were already there, and we dug deeper in the sand.

We fired about 30 rounds about dinner time, O.K. Smashing grapes. Sid saw one of our dive-bombers shot down. Several shells dropped near in the evening. Naturally, I was about 100 yds away from my well-dug trench, in the open. It was such a good one that Dick insisted on sharing it with me all night, sardine-like.



A Churchill tank passes through the narrow streets of Montefiore, Italy, 11 sept 1944. (Picture from Imperial War Museum)

Jim visited Montefiore (shown on Gothic Line map) a few days later, but failed in his vital mission to persuade a barber to to return with with him to the British camp.



Above: slit trench during the advance on the Gothic Line near Montelabbate, c. August 30 - 31 1944. Picture is of Corporal C. Charette, West Nova Scotia Regiment, and comes from the site: The Gothic Line: Canada's Month of Hell

"a shell had landed across the road, and wounded 6 Camerons. I helped carry one to the A.D.S."

Sept 13 1944
Woke - and found an incredible amount of sand in all my kit. Fired a good number of rounds in the morning, dropped one of our peculiar misfires just in front of Cpl Postlethwaite's mortar, no explosion. ...

After dinner we moved again, as yesterday, about 1 mile nearer the front. Got in again, bedded down, dug in. Some shells came pretty near our cookhouse. News that the other divs are pushing on. Still eating lbs of grapes.

Went to bed in the slit-trench. Awakened about 10 by a bang - and half my spoil-heap falling in on me. A shell had landed just across the road, and wounded 6 Camerons. I helped carry one to the A.D.S. Bloody bad show.

Sept 14 1944
Firing all morning and aft. Score at 6 PM about 120 bombs for our mortar. All O.K. Bags of work preparing bombs, we must have pasted them. Only one lot back, and that distant. Heard recently Coghill wounded. Rowberry said all bombs on target. Fired again till dark, then packed up in dark - what a game! A stack of empty bomb cartons like a timber-yard.

Sept 15 1944
Reveille at 5.30, packed in the dark, moved off 6.30. Halted about an hour at a village. As we stood about, a German soldier came up with a white flag and a safe conduct and surrendered. He was 34, from Graz, and friendly. Yates took him back on his bike. We went in one of the houses, found a pianola and enjoyed ourselves playing it...

"We buried him as best we could. Other bodies lay further up the road"

Continued to our next position and there Jo Dunkerley smashed his [truck? word illegible] trying to climb a bump. The truck was U/S [unserviceable], so was towed away. We put the mortars up, but did not fire. Jerry kept quiet, too. We ... then went to bury a dead private of the Queens, whose body was in our area. He stank, and his head was a skull covered with black stuff and maggots. He was a Private Pratt. We buried him, as best we could. Other bodies lay about further up the road.

In the aft. we packed up and moved back for a 36 hrs rest. We went miles past Montefiore, about 10 miles altogether, then found ourselves back at the farm we left this morning! We had lost our way, and eventually rejoined C Coy about 2 miles further back…

Sept 16 1944
Spent the morning cleaning the mortar. It needed it. Afterwards wrote home etc. NAAFI up – a bottle of beer! The C.Q.M.S. [Company Quartermaster Sergeant] opened shop – all replacements free of charge. It was like a bargain sale. I changed groundsheets and socks, and got a pair of new B.D. pants for denims. Joe's truck came back with a new back axle.

Sept 17 (Sun) 1944
Just to shake us, they told us at the last minute to bring rifles on parade, and gave us a pukka inspection. Many clangers dropped. Afterwards Cpl Possy, Joe Cash and myself set off in a truck to find a barber. We searched Morciano and Montefiore [see map], but couldn't find one willing to come back with us.

Div. canteen round in the morning, div. dance band in the aft., div. concert party in the evening...Taffy and Olsen, the chap who came with him, are staying with us as mortar numbers. We were told to pack, ready to move at 4 AM, but the early start was cancelled.

Sept 18 1944
The 4 AM start eventually became 9.30! We moved off to a concentration area just across the river. I spent the day washing all my clothes, also dug in.

Air borne landings in Holland.

Sept 19 1944
We packed up after breakfast, prepared for a move, which actually took place at dusk. The lads settled down to Housey [gambling game], so of course when Rowberry saw it he had us cleaning the mortars – a case of gilding the lily. … .

We moved into the middle of another convoy, but kept on by the light of search-lights, which lit everything up. Nonetheless, Joe got one wheel on a bank and nearly overturned the truck, but not quite. We went into harbour, and I slept in a ditch (dry). Some shells fell somewhere in the area.



A soldier's grave in Monte Titano, Sept. 1944

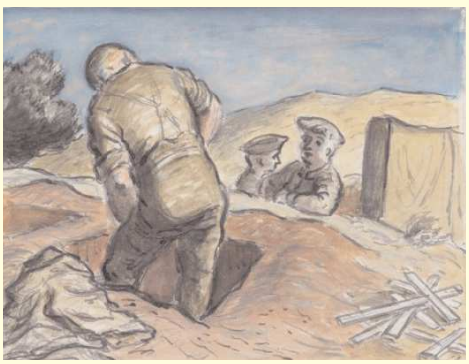
The 'D-Day Dodgers'

The term, used for allied servicemen who fought in Italy, was allegedly publicised by the MP Viscountess Astor. Understandably resented, it gave rise to a sarcastic song by Harry Pynn - of which 3 verses below. It was sung to the tune of the 8th Army's favourite song Lili Marlene. Jim - Dad - used to sing bits of it. **Janet**

We landed at Salerno,
A holiday with pay,
Jerry brought the band out
To cheer us on the way.
He showed us the sights and made us tea,
we all sang songs, the beer was free,
For we're the D-Day Dodgers,
Way out in Italy.

We stayed a week in Florence,
Polished off the wine,
Then thumbed our way to Rimini
Right through the Gothic Line.
Soon to Bologna we well go
When Jerry's gone across the Po
For we're the D-Day Dodgers,
The boys that D-Day dodged.

Look around the mountains
In the mud and rain,
You'll find scattered crosses,
Some which bear no name,
Heartbreak and toil and suffering gone
The boys beneath them slumber on,
For they're the D-Day Dodgers,
Who stayed in Italy.



A grave-digger beside the road to Tripoli, by Edward Ardizzone, 1943. (Note the crosses.)



Left: the Fifth Army in Lauro, Italy, Jan 19 1944. Lieutenant Olaf Branns sleeps in a haystack during a lull in the battle.

Below: ditched truck in the plain beyond Rimini - painted by Edward Ardizzone, 1944. Two British soldiers in greatcoats stand watching it near a ruined farmhouse.

(Both pictures from Imperial War Museum)

"I made a niche in a haystack, about 12 ft away from a dead German"

Sept 20 1944

…. Went forward again, in sight of the San Marino ridge, and mounted the mortars. Fired 15 bombs, and dug in. I got my bed down, and was in it when rain started. My blankets, groundsheet, bush-net and greatcoat suffered. I put them under what cover I could, and then we did a shoot. ... I got on a heap of sweetcorn under a porch, and kipped down as best I could. Earlier there had been some near shells, and shrapnel flying over.

Sept 21 1944

…. Drizzle soon began, and then it rained most of the day. I moved all my kit to a straw hut with Dick and one of the Phillipses. Got my bed down there, and was dry and comfortable. Everywhere a sea of mud, trucks stuck. No water, and most of the wells dry, so we had a heck of a job to get any for cooking, none for washing. No papers for us, but I saw an Oak belonging to the RAC. Our lads have reached the Rhine at Nijmegen. 13 pln are with us here. Got in bed at dusk, slept about 11 hrs.

Sept 22 1944

Woke to a blue sky and hot sun, though the ground was too wet to dry out. Strangely enough, water still difficult, though I got a wash in dubious rainwater. We got the mortars out, cleaned them and loaded the trucks. …Waiting all day for orders to move. We are now in San Marino territory. Moved out at dusk, after great heaving on trucks and trailers to get them on the road. As we turned away from San Marino Mt., shells began dropping. Two were unpleasantly near. I ducked so hard that I smashed my glasses on a water can, and cut my face. Whenever the truck stopped we piled out and dived for cover. I dived through a thorn bush and scratched my face again.

Reached harbour very bomb-happy indeed. On guard, but as we arrived at 12 and reveille was at 5 that wasn't much.I made a niche in a haystack, about 12 ft away from a dead German - who was in another niche in the same stack, and slept well.



Sept 23 1944

Packed up, preparatory to setting up mortars on the forward slope of the valley. The M.P. carrier got there, but couldn't get back. Our truck and Cpl. Brewer's set off along a ridge road in full enemy view. More shells were dropped near us and we had to dive in more ditches, (imaginary ones, we just lay flat).

We got as far as the OP (about 2 miles behind the mortar line!), then were stopped. We waited, then returned, about 60 MPH. Byrne, who was dropped off as guide, got a shell about a yard from him, but was flat down and only got a scratched nose.Spent the rest of the day reading etc, and slept in the haystack again. Woken in the middle of the night, told to prepare to move in 15 min. Dressed, packed up, loaded trailer and truck (we bashed another trailer up today - more kit to take), and waited for the order. Dozed about an hour or two, then told it was all off! Crawled back to my haystack, slept as I was.

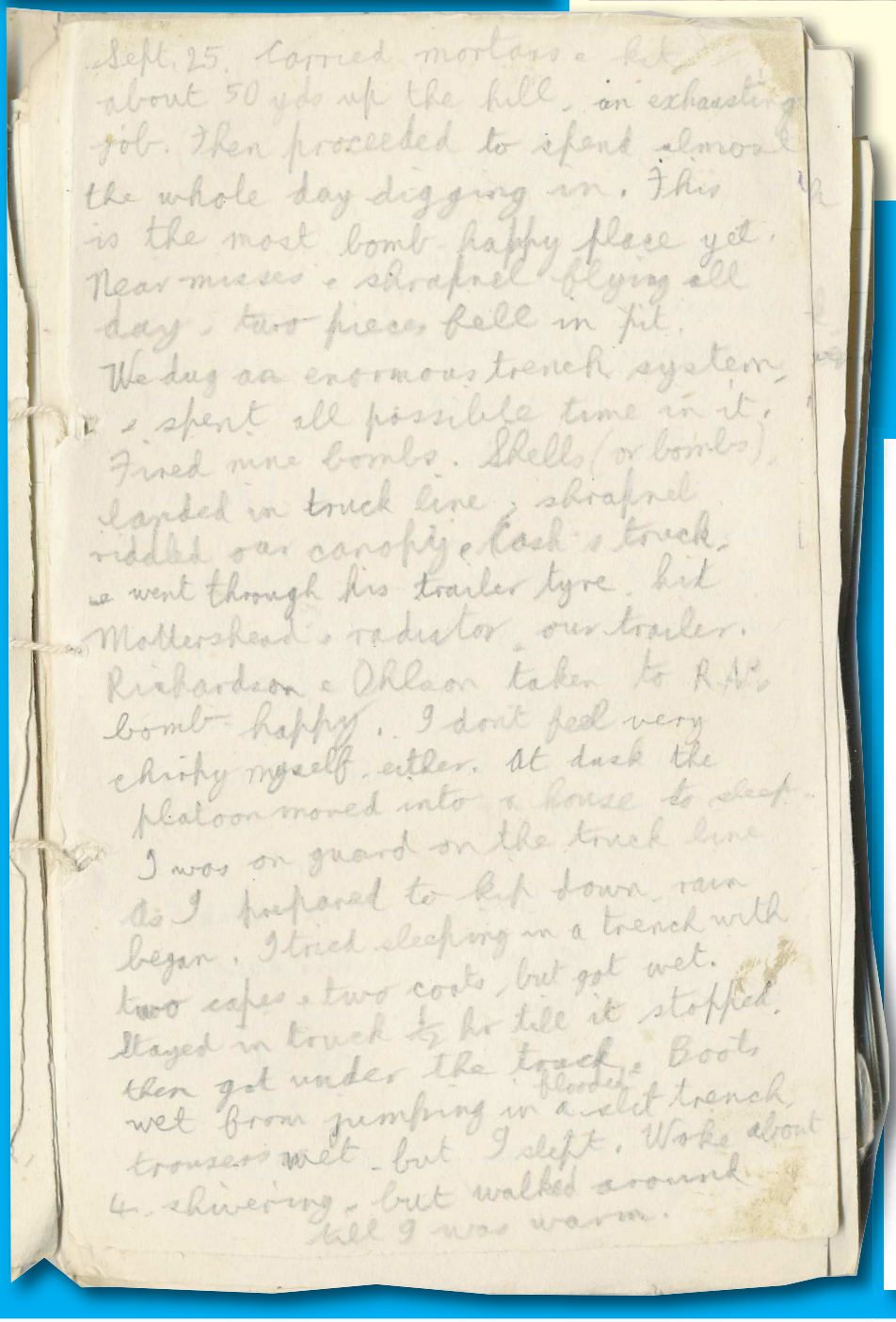
Sept 24 1944
Mr Douglas decided to have a formal First Parade, with arms, so we cleaned our boots and rifles, and went through the motions correctly. In the late morning we moved to a position about a mile ahead, but this side of the river (Marecchia?). A difficult track, the truck nearly went down a bank. Got our mortars in position, with all kit and bombs, cut down about 6 trees for clearance.

Fired 24 bombs apiece, then ordered to cease fire. Carried all kit back to trucks, nearly on our knees. A shower began, but soon stopped. With great heaving we got the trucks out (Joe Cash did a tank act!), and went forward. Crossed the river at dusk, safely, went into harbour at the other side. Alleged to be in enemy view, so camouflaged extensively, then dug in. Considerable shelling in area, a piece of shrapnel landed somewhere close. Trench narrow, shallow and short, so slept poorly.



German prisoners and a knocked out tank in the village of San Savino, Italy, 19 September 1944. (See Gothic Line map)

(Picture from the Imperial War Museum)


Sept. 25. Carried mortars & kit about 50 yds up the hill, an exhausting job. Then proceeded to spend almost the whole day digging in. This is the most bomb happy place yet. Near misses & shrapnel flying all day, two pieces fell in pit. We dug an enormous trench system, & spent all possible time in it. Fired nine bombs. Shells (or bombs) landed in truck line, shrapnel riddled our canopy & Cash's truck, & went through his trailer tyre, hit Mottershead's radiator our trailer. Richardson & Ohlson taken to R.A.'s bomb happy. I don't feel very chirpy myself, either. At dusk the platoon moved into a house to sleep. I was on guard on the truck line. As I prepared to kip down, rain began. I tried sleeping in a trench with two capes & two coats, but got wet. Stayed in truck ½ hr till it stopped, then got under the truck. Boots wet from jumping in a slit trench, trousers wet, but I slept. Woke about 4, shivering, but walked around till I was warm.

"Richardson and Ohlson taken to R.A.H., bomb happy. I don't feel very chirpy myself, either"

Sept 25 1944
Carried mortars and kit about 50 yds up the hill, an exhausting job. Then proceeded to spend almost the whole day digging in. This is the most bomb-happy place yet. Near misses and shrapnel flying all day, two pieces fell in pit. We dug an enormous trench system, and spent all possible time in it. Fired nine bombs. Shells (or bombs) landed in truck line, shrapnel riddled our canopy and Cash's truck, and went through his trailer tyre, hit Mottershead's radiator, our trailer. Richardson and Ohlson taken to R.A.H.[?], bomb happy. I don't feel very chirpy myself, either. At dusk the platoon moved into a house to sleep. I was on guard on the truck line. As I prepared to kip down, rain began. I tried sleeping in a trench with two capes and two coats, but got wet. Stayed in truck ½ hour till it stopped, then got under the truck. Boots wet from jumping in a flooded slit trench, ... but I slept. Woke about 4, shivering, but walked around till I was warm.

“a piece of shrapnel in Possy’s dinner!”

Sept 26 1944
Went up to the mortar line after breakfast, found a foot of water in our pit. Dug a channel and drained it, got baseplate out. Baseplate position hopeless, just mud, so dismounted mortar and cleaned it as best we could. Others fired a little. Shelling still bad, two bits of shrapnel landed in trench, one a yard in front, one a yard behind me. Stuff over all day, all of us utterly bomb-happy.Another tyre hit, and a piece of shrapnel in Possy’s dinner!Prepared to sleep in house above again, but, about 7, ordered to cease fire. Shoved everything on trucks, went like mad to house in river road. Down in cellar on mattresses, simply marvellous.

Sept 27 1944
A restful day at last. One lot of shells on the river bed, otherwise almost nothing. The 25-pdrs are right on top of us, and kept shaking our nerves, but I feel a lot better. Had a wash and shave, the first for 3 ½ days. At last Cpl Possy has a truck on loan from BHQ. Short the driver. Another good night.

Sept 28 1944
… Just before tiffin we were told mortars had to be in position about 2, a mile down the road. It was raining then and continued all day and night, with increasing wind. We carried kit about 100 yds up, did some firing. Got very wet. Fired on timed programme till 3 AM. One of the most miserable experiences of my life, stumbling out wet through in pouring rain and wind, through mud and flood. Then waiting in the farm, still wet and cold. An absolute bastard.

Sept 29 1944
Up before dawn and straight out to our mortar. The baseplate had gone too far down to fire, so we drained the pond and dug it out – a four hours job. Really hard graft. Remounted the mortar, and bedded in, did some ranging. We went up in shifts to the other house, where the cook etc. still is, to dry clothes etc.

Later made another base-plate position, properly dug, with bomb tins and stakes, and shifted the mortar. Expected to fire several hundred bombs tonight, so got several loads of ammo. Told eventually it was off, to our great relief. I was on guard, but got a decent sleep.

“a quagmire of tank tracks turned lakes”

Cold and light showers all day. The field between house and mortars is a quagmire of tank tracks turned lakes.

Sept 30 1944
Stayed in same position all day, going to other house in shifts as before. No firing, simply left mortars as they were. More ammo arrived, for no conceivable reason, and we had to stack it. Otherwise cleaned rifles, read..

Oct 1 (Sunday) 1944
Orders to cease fire. … Loaded up and set off for rest area. As before we went miles behind the line, then turned round and went back to it. We went right back to the building we used as an OP on Sept 23, the one behind the mortar line. No shelling this time, though!

The main building is a church, and we were billeted in that. We cleared debris, patched up a shell-hole in the wall, moved the pews and bedded down inside. Not really to my taste, but the rest of the house contains civilians. Rowberry and Douglas took one of their bedrooms, and as interpreter I had to explain. What a job!



German prisoners of war carrying wounded members of the 1st Canadian Corps through Cesena, Italy, October 21 1944. (Cesena fell to the allies on that date, according to Eighth Army News.)

(Picture from the site: The Gothic Line: Canada’s Month of Hell)

"Went into hospital, with me Dick Gill and Taffy Williams"

Oct 2 1944
Heavy rain all day. It must be bloody awful for the infantry. We cleaned the mortar, as best we could for the weather. It was in a terrible state. The CQMS [Company Quartermaster Sergeant] issued us with an extra blanket, B.D. and winter underclothing. We got long underpants and long-sleeved vests. One of M.G. 'walked' with a towel – I have lost no kit at all by theft while in the line, but now we are with them it is going wholesale. We all went for about a mile in the rain for a bath, and found the MBM[?] hadn't even arrived!

Oct 3 1944
A fine day, thank goodness. Mr Rowberry held an informal First Parade in the morning, and made a farewell speech. He has gone to 12 Pln. Cptn. Green is in dock, so Mr Douglas is in sole charge. … I squared my kit up and caught up with diary and letters. … A Jerry plane came over just after dusk and had a go.

Oct 4 1944
... Got orders to prepare to move – as usual a day before our rest is up.

Oct 5 1944
Ready to move at 6 AM, but the affair is off, probably for a few days. I handed my specs in for repair, did a little washing, otherwise read and wrote. ... Again I had to smooth down a ruffled Eytie.

Oct 8 (Sun) 1944
Diarrhoea worse than ever, went sick again. Went into hospital, with me Dick Gill and Taffy Williams. Taffy and Sgt. Dalziel went on to CCS [Casualty Clearing Station, I think]. All our detachment but for Joe are in now. A vile wet day. Very comfortable in bed, good food. ... Plenty of books, radio, multo bueno. ... 7,000 planes over Germany at once.

Oct 9 1944
… A very comfortable day, reading and writing. I saw Cpl. Hartley, who said that Cpl. Postlethwaite is also here, and that the lads expected to move at midday. Some rain in the morning, but fine later.



A gunner from a field artillery battery washes from an empty ammunition case while another cleans his muddy boots in a puddle, Italy, 5 December 1943. (Picture from Imperial War Museum.) With such primitive living conditions, it's little wonder Jim got the 'trots' badly enough to need hospital!

Oct 11 1944
… a party of us, including Cpl. Postlethwaite, went to No. 1 CCS. It was near Rimini, and we drove all round the town before finding it... Then we went on to no. 18 CCS at Morciano. I saw Lt. Madden with us. This place is less pleasant than the F.A., a long room, stretchers on trestles, no meals allowed, generally less cosy.

Oct 12 1944
It isn't so bad here on the whole. Possy is next to me, and Dick Gill, who arrived this aft., is opposite me. He seems rather ill. I am considerably improved. ... They have a wireless here, at the far end of the room.

Oct 14 1944
... The M.O. said I was going out tomorrow and commented unfavourably on my dirty boots. ...

Oct 15 1944
Out of dock. We went in front of the C.O. for the formal interview:- 'Any complaints?', then vamoosed. We were told we could either make our own way back or go to the 202 transit camp. I went down there ... We were in biggish double-roofed tents, with straw in the floor...

Oct 18 1944
Returned to unit. ...Went to BHQ [possibly Battalion Headquarters], in a big house about a mile along the ridge, where also is D Coy HQ. I am in 12 Pln for now ... We are sleeping in the house, quite cushy. ...

Oct 19 1944
...a big party of us went down to Santarcengelo. ... We stayed there, so as to see the film in the evening.I queued up about an hour, then some latecomers went to try and get in by priority. The rear end of the queue made a rush, and the result was one big jam at the doors for the next half hour. There was plenty of bad temper, and argument with the red-caps. Like many more I got squeezed out, but later I got in by a side door and stood at the back to see 'Stage Door Canteen'.

"Very glad to see the lads again, they have had it rough, but no casualties"

Oct 21 1944
... in the stores 3-tonner to 15 Pln, who are near Morciano, to see about kit. Cptn. Ross is QC, and I saw him about getting back. ... Very glad to see the lads again, they have had it rough, but no casualties.

Oct 22 (Sunday) 1944
... My birthday parcel arrived from home, a really good one. Polish and all kinds of toilet stuff, sweets, books, laces, Whiffs etc. Cpt. Ross came for a conference, and arranged to have me back in 15 Pln, to my relief. I have Sgt. Linnett to thank for that. He took me back in the aft., and I got well fixed up in the house. … We have electric light in one room, crowded but decent.

Oct 23 1944
P.T. in the morning, Douglas took us for one of his favourite trots, not too bad. ... Offered job as Ross's batman [officer's servant], but refused.

Oct 24 1944
... Major Bob took me on another interpreting job. Later we took the trucks down to the river and washed them. ... we went to the canteen. Tea and decent cakes, and a 'shop' upstairs that had nearly everything in – cigs, chocolate, soap, everything. Free issue and NAAFI up. I am accumulating supplies for my birthday.

Oct 25 1944
I had volunteered for a sort of first aid course, so Sullivan and I missed first parade and went down to the 183 Fd. Amb. at Morciano. We found it was simply helping the orderlies with the sick. [Jim went there again each morning for a while, though he had a break on Sunday 29 when he saw 'Stage Door Canteen' again - with a seat this time!]

Oct 28 1944
... to Riccione - we had been told there were two canteens and three cinemas there. ... a nice little place, with a smashing Canadian rest camp. Unfortunately everything was reserved for the Canadians, so we unanimously went back ...

Oct 31 1944
Up 5.45, to send our blankets in for disinfestation. It shook us! As usual, wrote and played whist...

Nov 1 1944
... A letter from Cpl. Etches, showing him to be in a pretty bad way still. Again spent most of the day playing whist. Pinky and Yates rashly challenged Jet and me to a round for 50 l each, and lost.

"the hangover started ... within sounds of guns"

Nov 6 1944
My 21st birthday. A typical army morning. Got up, dressed, folded blankets, drew water from well and washed in tin hat. Breakfast, then walked down to Field Ambulance. … Packed up ready to move tomorrow. Ate my hoarded sweets and chocolate during the day. Got a letter from Southport wishing me many happy returns.

Set out with Pinky, Ricky and Bagnall, and my two bottles of beer, for a night out. Went down to vino shop in town, found a queue outside waiting for opening time. Sid said he knew another place, so we set off. … Found the 'Osteria', but 'niente vino'. However, we waited half an hour while they fetched some, then mixed it with the beer. I got utterly soused. We also got some bread, and I smoked my cigars and we talked – I don't know what about. When we could drink no more, we got a lift back to town, then walked to the billet. Bagnall had to be supported, but we all made it. And so to bed. Multo buono.

Nov 7 1944
Reveille 4, breakfast 5, move off 6. On waking I was still drunk, but not yet 'hung-over', so I got packed up easily. After moving off the hangover started, and I felt like death till 2 PM. I was sick once, and sorry all the time. Our truck had a puncture, but we got in about 2, somewhere near Forli.[See Forli on left.] Good billets in a hamlet on a hill, very windy. Within sound of guns, but not (I hope) in range. Friendly people. No electric light, so evening activity restricted. I paid for my pleasure, but it was worth it.



Townspeople making a house-to-house dash in Forli under shellfire. Artist Edward Ardizzone recorded the event on 10 November 1944: 'much shelling and Spandau fire ... streets empty except for a few soldiers, though we are told all the houses are inhabited with families in the basements...'
(Picture from Imperial War Museum)

Nov 8 1944
… Douglas came round 10 mins after reveille, raising hell. He seems to have decided to be a pukka bastard. The other bloke, Gotto, seems all right. Tat took a truck to a well - and got stuck. Six of us wore ourselves out pushing him out....

Nov 10 1944
Woke to find the mountains white with snow, likewise our own hilltop, though this latter soon turned to mud... .

Nov 11 1944
... A cushy routine - formal first parade, and little work, then writing, carding and studying Italian. I spent most of the evening with the Eyties, and got on marvellously with them. [He says On **November 12:** 'Acted as C.I.D. to try and recover a clock for the Eyties.']

Nov 13 1944
...The Eyties here seem quite set up with me. I know them well now, the married couple. Mama from Spezia, little Santo and Carla. The kids in the hamlet have been given so many cigs that they are getting cheeky now.



British signallers take cover in a ditch as an enemy mortar bomb explodes near their Jeep, 14-16 September 1943, Italy (Picture from Imperial War Museum)

"They got a direct hit onMottram's truck, which went up in flames"

Nov 14 1944
In readiness to move all day. …We pulled out in mid aft, and went forward till dark, a cold and nervy ride. Then all went into houses ... we found apples, potatoes, pears and eggs, which last we had fried for supper. Really a bonanza..[It sounds as though the lads were in the habit of using empty houses they assumed abandoned by Italians fleeing the war - and eating whatever perishables they found. Sometimes - as in this case - the owners embarrassingly showed up!]

Nov 15 1944
Boiled eggs for breakfast, very nice too. The old lady of the house turned up, but made no fuss … We pulled out at mid-morning, and drove to a farm about 400 yds from Jerry - who had left it 3 hrs before, taking a lot of their clothes. They made us welcome, vino etc, and brought two enormous oxen to tow our truck out of the mud. We put two mortars up here, two at a farm 100 yds up the road. Pln HQ at one between…

… As I was at Pln HQ, having tea, several rebels stonked us. They got a direct hit on Mottram's truck, which went up in flames. I had an unpleasantly near view. The truck and two haystacks burnt all night. No casualties, but some bedding lost. Spent an interesting evening, watching an Eytie woman with self-raising skirts. [Eh?!!] More rebels, and some Vickers [a machine gun] a few hundred yards away rattled all day and all night. Guard spread out again, 1 ½ hrs each. A bit crowded, but I slept all right.

Nov 16 1944
…. More rebels and shells, largely on the same target. Moved later to Povere, meaning to wait a while, and stayed all night. An Eytie grocer's there, bashed about and looted. We went round – not much left, though. Had a sing-song after dinner...

Nov 17 1944
Packed up, and moved fairly early. In low hills this time, not on the flat. As usual, we went to the wrong place first, but eventually got in position all right, with a bit of carrying. We borrowed oxen to bring bombs up! Did a fair bit of shooting, but soft earth messed the baseplates up. I got well dug in. A decent casa to sleep in, though upstairs. ...

Nov 18 1944
Continued getting bombs up, with the oxen pulling one of our trailers. As interpreter, I was in charge of the job – hard work too. Plenty of digging on the mortar line too. More firing on the enemy, but the baseplate went down and flooded, so we didn't do the expected night firing. Bought a cockerel from the Eyties and roasted it with potatoes. ...

"Spitfires diving on them all the time"

Nov 19 (Sun) 1944
At work all day with the oxen again, bringing hundreds of bombs up. Meanwhile the remaining mortars have been re-sited on drier ground. The RAF gave Jerry a bashing today, Spitfires diving on them all the time. ...

Nov 20 1944
They tried to get a carrier and trailer up the hill, but it bellied. I got six oxen on the job again, but we couldn't get it out. We had a big shoot at 3.20 – all the bombs prepared and laid out. We got about 100 off, just dropping them down, one after another. The barrel turned black with heat! In fact we worked till dusk on ammo and the mortars. About 9.15, when I had been on stag a few minutes, we were called out for D.F., and fired 40-50. Our mortar in the pit wouldn't traverse, so we fired from another mounted beside the pit. Cpl Skinner has hurt himself, so I put bombs down. We worked like mad, and stood down about midnight.

About 15 min. after standing down we were called out again. Ammo ran low, so some of us were set on carrying it up from the dump. We kept on like this for 3 hours, with light rain, firing, bringing ammo and trying to keep the mortars in action. When we stood down at 3.15 both our baseplates were on end, so our detachment slept till reveille, though the others were called out twice. 21 hrs continuous struggle!



Above: Two Spitfire IXs of No. 241 Squadron, Royal Air Force, fly over mountainous country south of Rome, January 1944.





Above: as artist Edward Ardizzone recorded in his Italy diary on September 16 1944: '...A large peasant family ... emerge from their earth shelter. The children, frightened by aeroplanes, on tiptoe to fly in ever direction.' (Both pictures from the Imperial War Museum)

Left: Spitfire Mark IXs and VCs of No. 232 Squadron RAF, south of Salerno, Italy, Sept. or Oct. 1943. Local peasants in a bullock cart remove tree stumps from a new runway. (www.ww2incolor) (As Jim records, in rural Italy in World War 2, bullocks and oxen were part of the war effort!)

Nov 21 1944
Set to work, dug and heaved the baseplates out, one damaged, but we got both mortars in again. Cleared the debris, brought more ammo up, got things straight again by 4. Weather cleared again, thank goodness, and this morning's big attack is said to be doing well. Got some time to myself at last, wrote letters. The western front is moving again, the Rhine reached, Metz taken. Short nearly killed yesterday by a shell near our ammo dump.

Nov 22 1944
… In the aft. we carried the ammo up to the farm, dismounted the mortars and carried them to the trucks – and cleared out. To my relief they allowed us to leave the ammo stacked where it is. I got some eggs off the Eyties for soap… Had the first aid kit handed over to me. ...

We pulled out just before tea to Villa Povere, and stayed the night there. Not on guard for a change. The carrier has been rescued, but is U/S [unserviceable], so we have a 15 cwt instead.

Nov 23 1944
Stayed at Villa Povere all day, waiting for orders to move. Spent the time writing, addressing my Xmas airgraphs etc.[Airgraphs explained lower down] Also changed my underwear, the first time since Morciano. Sgt. Foot held a rifle inspection! We moved forward at dusk, along the Faenza road, and took over a position already dug by 13 pln. We were already out of range, so just put the mortars in and didn't bother much. Stag 8-9, then slept on a real bed!

Nov 25 1944
The usual chaos: reveille 6 O'Clock; at 6.55 we were told to be ready to move by 7; actual time of departure 9.30. Mist and low cloud all day, slight rain in morning. We drove round Italy till about 2 PM, and eventually took up position on dead flat ground near Faenza. A decent casa, but the area was like a rifle range. Everything from Minnies to 210's came down round us all day. We dug in in record time, mortar pits of course. Did harassing fire all night. Plenty of shrapnel around, too. Our mortar wouldn't bed in properly, and Smith and I spent hours digging the baseplate out and putting it in again. Then guard 4-6.

"Spandau fire cutting through the trees round the mortar line in the early evening"



Above: German MG42 machine gun crew fighting in Monte Cassino, 1 April 1944; Below: German paratrooper with MG42 machine gun, Rome, Italy, Sept 1943



'Spandau fire': presumably Jim means the German-made 'Spandau' machine gun or MG 42.Notable for its exceptionally high rate of fire, it was termed 'Hitler's buzzsaw'. It was sometimes called 'Spandau' by British troops, from the manufacturer's plate noting the district of Berlin where some were produced. As these German Federal Archive photos show, they were in use by Germans in Italy.

Nov 26 (Sun) 1944
…. We spent the morning extending our earthworks. Not as much stuff coming over. I had a look round the upper floor of the house, beautifully furnished. As first aid man, I was sent to tend an Eytie woman who was wounded, but fortunately my services weren't needed. Harassing shoot as last night, but the baseplate finished before the night was out, so I got a little more sleep. Not very pleasant out in the dark and rain.

Nov 27 1944
Spent the whole morning working in the rain getting the baseplate out. One hell of a job, and we got definitely wet. In the aft. we cleaned the mortar, and set it up in the drive of the house. Only 2 shoots, 9 PM and 12.30 PM, and it bedded in well, so we were laughing. It appears that the planes that were over here yesterday firing M.G.'s were FW 190's. Cpt. Green proved rather obstinate on mortar matters, wanting us to put the mortar back in a pit of water. One shoot was at 1900! Spandau fire cutting through the trees round the mortar line in the early evening.

"One of the most exciting nights of my life.... We did three big shoots on the Spandaus"

Nov 28 1944
Another day of work, cleaning the mortar, strengthening the sangar [A small, temporary fortified position - picture further down] and digging a slit trench. I was on guard 10-12, so stayed up writing home. One of the most exciting nights of my life. Spandau fire continuous till nearly midnight, hitting the house and trailer parked beside it, and whipping over the mortars.

We did three big shoots on the Spandaus. In the first, they opened up as we were laying on, and we lay behind our low sangar as the bullets cut the trees. Then the rest stood down, and Heeley and I, on guard, were told to fetch about 40 more bombs up.

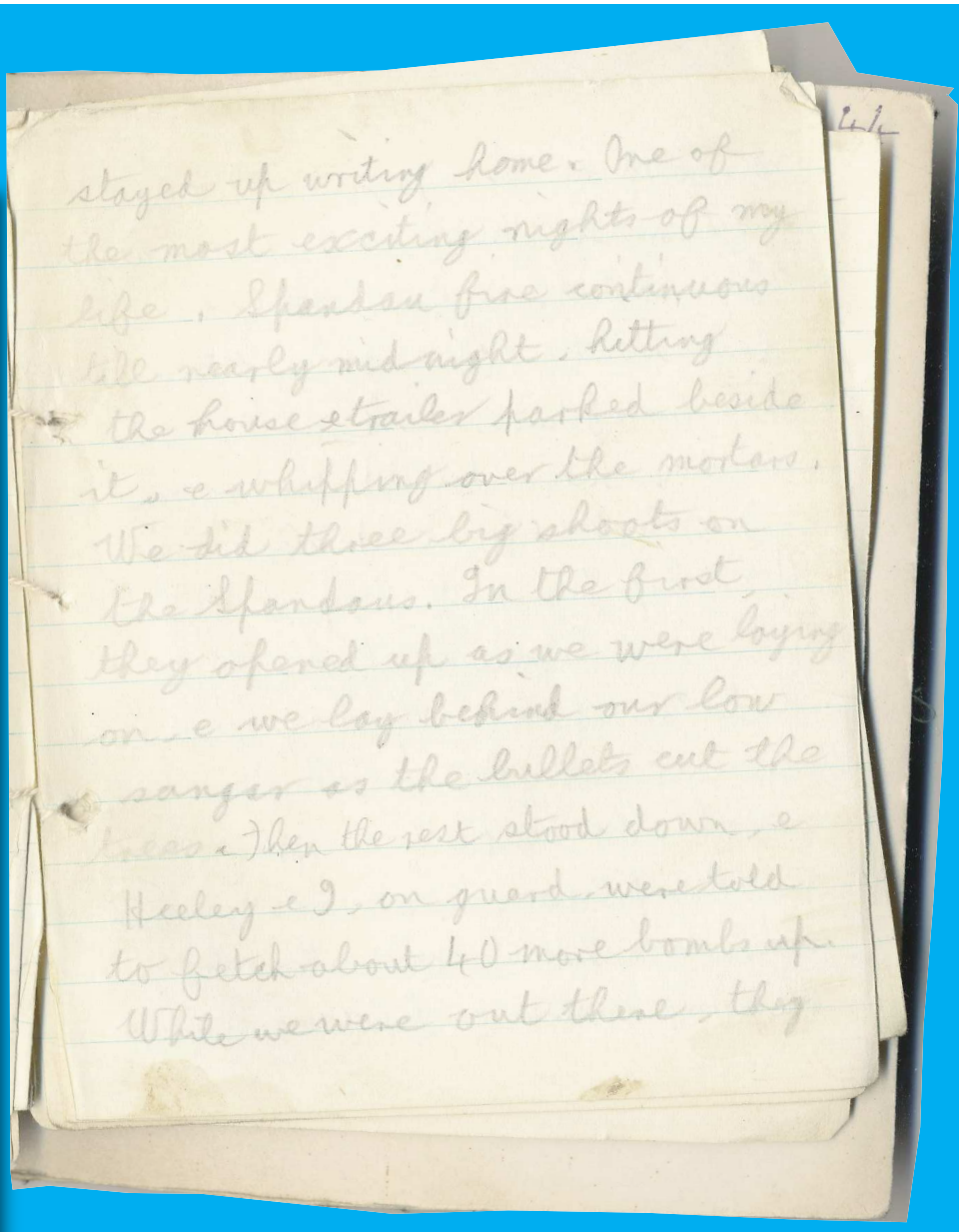
While we were out there, they opened up on us again, and I lay flat in the mud behind a gatepost. After that they kept clear of us, but I was thoroughly bomb happy. Our baseplate went down, so we dug out and put it in again. To bed about 1.30.

Nov 29 1944
We had hoped to get some time in bed, but had to spend the day working on our sangars. All four mortars were put in near ours, and the place is now honeycombed with trenches and embankments. Bags of rumours flying round about pulling out. Sgt. Linnett fetched in a carboy of Marsala. I sampled it in the evening, and found it very potent. A decent long sleep for a change.

Nov 30 1944
Further work on our fortifications and putting buckshee baseplates in, building sangars round them, and improving our existing protection.The garden now looks like a blitzed area. The weather remains the same, dull and misty with occasional rain. No more Spandau fire, but a few odd shells around. Sampled that smashing Marsala again, and got really washed up on it. Life made uncomfortable by mud outside, cold and darkness within.

Dec 1 1944
Programme as before. Weather improved after tiffin. Wharton and Sullivan returned, so I am free of my medical responsibilities. A lot of bombs brought up to unload after dusk. I learned that Phillips 24 [?] and Yates are in dock.

Dec 2 1944
We had all day pretty well to ourselves. I did


stayed up writing home. One of
the most exciting nights of my
life, Spandau fire continuous
till nearly midnight, hitting
the house & trailer parked beside
it, & whipping over the mortars.
We did three big shoots on
the Spandaus. In the first
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trees. Then the rest stood down, &
Heeley & I, on guard, were told
to fetch about 40 more bombs up.
While we were out there, they

"Artillery barrage throughout"

one job, map work for Cpt. Green. Otherwise read a little, talked a little, listened to the radio a little, and generally messed about. In mid-morning Jerry dropped about a dozen 88s all round the house, very close, scared us.

Dec 3 1944
… Had a 'bath' right after dinner, improvised in a canvas hip bath, then went to bed to keep warm. Two Jerry aircraft dashed over during the morning. …A big shoot from 7 till 8 PM, in support of an attack. Trouble at first – 3 of the mortars were out of action in the first 10 bombs, baseplate trouble. We transferred to our spare mortar, and after a lot of messing about with posts, ammo and [word illegible] lamps, fired about 90 bombs successfully.

Midway through the shoot, rebels came over, one landing beside our old pit in the next field. We lay behind the sangar. Wharton went bomb-happy again, and ran into the house. Artillery barrage throughout, some of it nearly hitting us. Called out again 3 times to shoot, the last being 2 AM. All successful. Guard 4-5. Managed a little sleep.

Dec 4 1944
Spent the morning digging out our original baseplate, preparing it and putting it in, and generally reinforcing the whole excavation. … None of our pln will get home this time, but Cpls Brewer, Hignett and Skinner get leave in Rome this week.

Dec 5 1944
Slept fully dressed all last night, but surprisingly, no call. Woke with feet frozen. No work, except marking map up for Cptn. Green...

C.S.M. [Company Sergeant Major] Smythe took Wharton away at 2 AM last night.

Dec 6 1944
Awakened at reveille to fire 6 bombs. Cpt. Green held a debate after break on home leave. It seems that under present arrangements no one in mortar Coy is ever likely to get home leave. Played Solo all aft., very enjoyable. Fired in the evening, in light rain for 3 hrs. ...

Dec 7 1944
… Intermittent fire during day. Smith makes a good No. 1. Mottershead returned from dock. Did a shoot about 9.30 – 36 bombs. Then had to get our baseplate out and put the mortar in again, after first taking all our kit and ammo over to a spare mortar. Finished about 12.15. I had just got in bed when Sid came to ask me to interpret for some Italian-speaking Indians!

Dec 8 1944
… No firing or mortar work, so I did various jobs. Cpt. Green had me up for half an hour's Italian conversation with him, useful.

I am also still marking up his map. Sgt. Foot went sick, and couldn't get back till late because of road repairs. We thought he must have been stonked! Dick Gill is at CRU.

Dec 9 1944
Another lazy morning, spent principally in reading papers just arrived from home. Just before lunch received instructions to move in 2 hrs. Rushed around packing up, and got everything on the trucks in a heap. Drove off about 2. As we turned into the Via Emilia, I said, 'Anyway, he must be out of range now.' Next second, a 210 landed behind us, followed by several others. No damage.

We reached Forli about 4, billeted on the 4th floor of the Technical College, a great, handsome building. I wore myself out climbing the great staircase. Went out with Bagnall and Pinky to the Church of Scotland canteen, then met some more lads. Some Eytie troops took us to their billets. We spent the evening drinking excellent wine and singing with them. Returned to billets, blotto, about 10, leaving Baggy behind. He got in all right.

Dec 10 (Sun) 1944
Moved off about 9, a bitterly cold day. Fine and clear, but we nearly froze. Travelled via Savignano and Santarcangelo. At lunch I saw Dick Gill, just arrived from CRU. Very glad to see him. Reached Ancona about 5, then went on through darkness till about 10, when we reached Petritoli. Cold, but relieved, we had supper, then kipped down. Excellent billets.







Messages by microfilm

In order to reduce weight and size for mail transportation in World War 2, letters could be copied to microfilm and printed back to paper upon arrival. The British versions were called airgraphs.

Above left: form for British Christmas 1944/New year 1945 pictorial airgraph. Left: poster advertising airgraphs.

Above: gunners resting beside their armoured car, with Indian soldiers keeping watch in their sangars on the ridge behind. (Picture by Edward Ardizzone, 1942, from the Imperial War Museum)